



An illustration of Malacca, which was taken from the Portuguese by the Dutch in 1641. An earlier attack by the Dutch in 1605 had failed.

FOLLOWING A SCOTTISH INVASION OF ENGLAND IN 1639, in April 1640 Charles I (1600–49) **recalled the parliament** he had dismissed 11 years earlier. He needed approval to raise taxes for an army. Determined not to submit to its lists of grievances, he dismissed it, but a second invasion in August forced a recall. In December 1641, Parliament presented a **Grand Remonstrance**, an accusation of royal abuses of power. The king responded, in January 1642, with an attempt to arrest his parliamentary opponents. By August, the **country was at war**.

Life dancing to music

Poussin's *A Dance to the Music of Time* shows four dancing figures representing poverty, labor, wealth, and pleasure in a perpetual cycle.



By 1640, French painter **Nicolas Poussin** (1594–1665) completed *A Dance to the Music of Time*, a **key work of the era**. Poussin stressed clarity and order rather than the emotion and color of the Baroque style dominant at that time.

From 1641, a devastating plague struck China, further **weakening a Ming China** threatened by both the Manchu military to the north and increasingly lawless bands of peasants roaming the country, victims of repeated famines. An almost complete **breakdown of central control** in China followed.

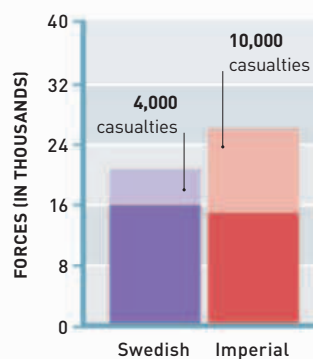
Continuing Dutch encroachment on the territory and trade of the Portuguese in Asia saw the **capture of the key trading base of Malacca** in 1641. It would prove a valuable cornerstone of the vast Dutch Empire in the East Indies.



A depiction of the Battle of Rocroi, fought on May 19, 1643. It resulted in the crushing victory of a French army over a Spanish force.

THE COURSE, NOT TO MENTION THE CAUSES, of the **English Civil War** that began in August 1642 was never clear cut. It pitted a **king bent on absolutism** against a Parliament determined not so much to overthrow the monarchy as to reassert its claim to **shared sovereignty in the government** of the kingdom. As the opening battles were fought, Charles I proved himself a surprisingly obstinate and able war leader. However, he was soon to become undone, not just by his compulsive deviousness but by the fact that he found himself confronting increasingly assertive and better organized Parliamentarian forces. These would be largely dominated by the formidably imposing figure of **Oliver Cromwell** (1599–1658), a Puritan, East-Anglian country squire and Member of Parliament. The war's significance, at least in English terms, was to be that Parliament could claim greater legitimacy than that of any king: in short, that **Parliament could restrain a king**, divinely sanctioned or not, held to have broken his trust with his people.

Eleven years after the village of Breitenfeld, in Saxony, had seen King Gustavus Adolphus of Sweden defeat a Holy Roman Empire army (see 1631), the **Second Battle of Breitenfeld** in October 1642 saw another decisive victory for Sweden in the Thirty Years' War. Sweden was subsequently free to occupy Leipzig and the rest of Saxony, further **strengthening Protestantism** in Central Europe,



Second Battle of Breitenfeld

The imperial army of the Holy Roman Empire suffered heavy losses at the hands of the Swedish army at Breitenfeld, in Saxony.

and making the Catholics of the Holy Roman Empire more amenable to negotiation.

The overwhelming French defeat of Spain at the **Battle of Rocroi** in northeast France in May 1643 put to an end to hopes of a Spanish triumph against either of the Dutch Republic or France in the Thirty Years' War. **Spain was already on the defensive** against both countries. Rocroi marked the end of its dreams of European imperial dominance. The Spanish army in Flanders was destroyed, **losing almost all its most experienced infantry** in the battle. Combined with its internal struggles against the Catalonians and the Portuguese, and its chronic shortage of money, Spain risked permanent eclipse. In the short term, defeat reduced the threat from the Dutch, who were anxious that they had potentially swapped the prospect of Spanish

domination for that of control by the French. In the longer term, **Spanish decline seemed inevitable**.

In 1643, Italian physicist and mathematician **Evangelista Torricelli** (1608–47) made a major contribution to scientific method in Europe with his **invention of the mercury barometer**. He had not intended to make this invention, but while working on a water pump for the Duke of Tuscany, and substituting the much heavier mercury for water, he realized that the rising and falling of a column of mercury in a tube sealed at one end was due to **changes in atmospheric pressure**.



Torricelli's barometer

In this engraving, Torricelli demonstrates the existence of atmospheric pressure through the use of mercury-filled tubes.

- April 1640 Short Parliament, in England, called by Charles I
- May 1640 Catalan revolt against Castilian military impositions breaks out
- November 1640 Long Parliament called, ending Charles I's personal rule
- 1641 Dutch take Portuguese possession of Malacca
- 1640 Nicolas Poussin completes *A Dance to the Music of Time*
- December 1640 End of Iberian Union; John IV proclaimed king of Portugal
- 1641 Revolts begin against Ming rule in China; plague sweeps through China
- November 22, 1641 Grand Remonstrance of English Parliament

- January 4, 1642 Charles I attempts arrest of parliamentary opponents
- January 8, 1642 Italian astronomer and physicist Galileo Galilei dies (b. 1564)
- October 23, 1642 Battle of Edgehill is drawn in First English Civil War
- 1642 Kaifeng Flood kills 300,000 in China
- 1642 Dutch sailor Abel Tasman (1603–59) discovers Tasmania and New Zealand
- January 4, 1643 English astronomer, mathematician, and physicist Isaac Newton born (d. 1727)
- May 19, 1643 Battle of Rocroi sees French crush Spanish
- May 14, 1643 Accession of infant Louis XIV of France
- 1642 Montreal founded by French
- October 23, 1642 Second Battle of Breitenfeld sees Swedes defeat Imperial army
- 1642 Dutch painter Rembrandt van Rijn (1606–69) paints *The Night Watch*
- 1643 Evangelista Torricelli invents mercury barometer, Tuscany